you mourn," says Koechlin. "That person is gone—the one who could just do whatever she wanted, when she wanted. Everything now is geared around the child. What you gain is much harder to describe. When you see a child grow, time takes on a different perspective. Unlike adults, you see their ageing process so clearly. You literally have to change their clothes and shoes every single year! Motherhood makes you more anxious and, at the same time, it also makes you remember the things you found exciting as a child."

That awareness of time has reframed how Koechlin approaches her scripts. While she doesn't censor her choices or shy away from dark material—she is currently gearing up for *Anarth*, a Hindi horror series for Emmay Entertainment, where she, again, plays a mother—she is far more selective about what takes her away from home.

Having relocated to Goa to give her six-year-old daughter a childhood anchored in nature, Koechlin is aware of the fleeting aspect of these early years. "I don't want to do everything that comes my way. I really wait for something that will push me in a direction that's really exciting," she says. "I just want to rush back to my daughter, because I know that by the time she's ten, she probably won't even want to hang out with me anymore!" Until then, the actor is content to let Sappho learn the names of birds that frequent their garden back home, savouring every moment of the magic before the inevitable independence of the double digits takes over. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

Belly of the Beast *premiered at Kamani, Delhi, on* **Jun. 27-28**, *and will be performed at NCPA, Mumbai, on* **Jul. 11-12**

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Curtain Call

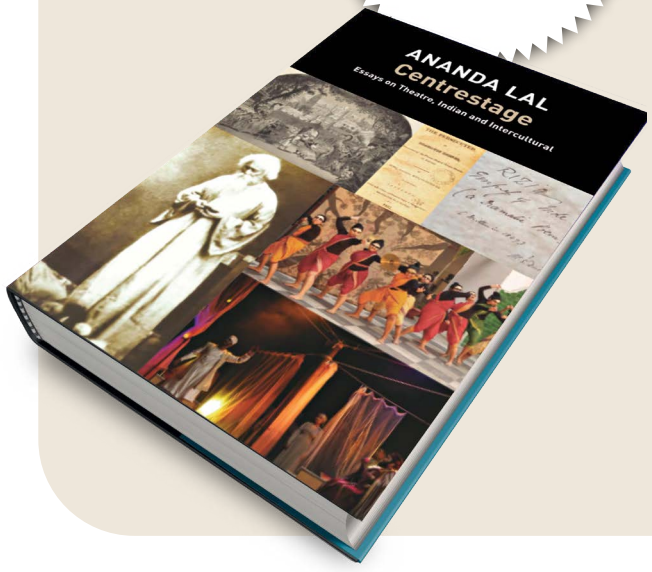
THIS COLLECTION OF NINE ESSAYS BY ANANDA LAL TRACES THE EARLY HISTORY OF INDIAN THEATRE AND ITS MODERN AVATARS

With ageing infrastructure and little patronage, theatre in India has been treated as a forgotten, unwanted child for decades. This, in turn, is reflected in the dearth of meaningful writing on Indian theatre. *Centrestage* fills in that lacuna with deep research and insights. A former professor of English at Jadavpur University, Kolkata, Ananda Lal has spent the better part of the past five decades reviewing theatre productions, besides being a prominent theatre director himself.

Lal divides the book into two distinct parts, the first delving into the influence that the English language has had on Indian theatre. He examines three English plays—*The Persecuted*, *Rizia* and *Kaminee*—written by Indian playwrights in the early nineteenth century. He carefully details his research on everything, from the performances to audience receptions, while highlighting the lack of record-keeping, documentation and archival material.

READERS ARE ALSO INTRODUCED TO *INTERCULTURAL INDIAN DRAMA*, FOLLOWED BY A TREATISE ON PETER BROOK'S *MAHABHARATA*

CENTRESTAGE: ESSAYS ON THEATRE, INDIAN AND INTERCULTURAL
By Ananda Lal
SEAGULL BOOKS
₹699; 197 pages



The second part of this collection focuses on intercultural theatre and the challenges presented by the sub-genre, both in India and globally. Lal briefly discusses the plagiarism of western works by adapting these stories to Indian milieus; he juxtaposes this with examples of Indian performing arts (dance, yoga, mythology) being appropriated by the West. In what might arguably be the most interesting chapter of this book, Lal introduces the reader to the theory and practice of intercultural Indian drama, followed by a treatise on Peter Brook's *Mahabharata* and an interview with the director conducted in 1989 during his visit to Kolkata. One of the most interesting experiments in the space, Lal talks about the differences in audience reactions to the play in India and the West, and how stripping away the culture from the story might have something to do with it. ■

—Karishma Upadhyay